

This section is a supplementary narrative intended to fill a previously left logical gap.

While reviewing the deductions I have already completed, I noticed that in the section detailing the formation of the Chinese bureaucratic system, I pointed out that it was the immense pressure exerted by the Xiongnu (匈奴) on China during the Western Han Dynasty that forced the Han Empire into a drastic response. This became the primary factor causing an overly perfected bureaucratic system to emerge in China during an overly early classical period.

However, this presents a question. Since the heavy pressure from the north during the Han Dynasty was the cause of the premature maturity of the bureaucratic system, and as is well known, after the Han Dynasty—especially during the **restoration-bureaucratic period** (复辟官僚时期) following the end of the **Ru Guan** (Entering the Pass / 入关) by ethnic minorities during the Sixteen Kingdoms and the Northern and Southern Dynasties—the threat to the Central Plains dynasties from the north, particularly from the newly risen Northeast region, still existed. The occurrences of ethnic minorities **Ru Guan** even became more frequent.

Does there exist a possibility, then, that the military pressure China faced (*primarily from the northern borders*) not only initially led to the formation of the premature bureaucratic system, but also became the reason the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚体制) was maintained after the **feudalization** (封建化) process was halted?

In fact, for me, relying solely on my volume of reading and life experience, I can intuitively deny this possibility. Therefore, when recording this previously, I subconsciously did not intend to treat this as an issue. But to persuade others, one obviously cannot rely on "how I feel." Next, I will explain from three aspects to negate this possibility.

1. The Threat of the Xiongnu Was Indeed Unique in Chinese History

(1, 匈奴人的威胁的确在中国历史上与众不同)

The first aspect: the pressure—especially the psychological pressure—brought upon China by the Xiongnu at their zenith was overwhelmingly massive compared to other formidable enemies that later appeared in northern China.

That is to say, even though China's close proximity to the Mongolian Plateau meant it would continuously suffer unimaginable military pressure from nomadic tribes originating there until the Qing Dynasty pacified Mongolia, the oppression and deterrence the Xiongnu inflicted upon the contemporaneous Chinese regime still possessed a marked uniqueness among all the various Mongolian-plateau regimes.

First, setting aside the psychological heavy pressure brought by the Xiongnu, as the first nomadic empire, upon the newborn Han Empire under specific circumstances. Judging merely from the balance of power recorded in historical materials, the only regime capable of posing a military threat to China comparable to the Xiongnu was the Mongol Empire after Genghis Khan's unification.

The fact is, even when Genghis Khan had just unified Mongolia and the Mongolian regime was rising like the morning sun, the military force it could mobilize was no more than a hundred thousand. By contrast, even during the 20 years following their catastrophic strategic defeat in the Battle of Mobei, the Xiongnu could still maintain a combat force of that size.

People easily judge the relative strength of the Xiongnu Empire and the Mongol Empire by their successes and failures in their conquests. However, a point I believe must be particularly emphasized is this: **the very reason the Mongol Empire could become powerful enough to conquer the largest contiguous territory possessed by any regime in human history (*roughly matching the British Empire at its zenith*) was, in itself, the result of China being severely weakened by the bureaucratic system.**

What people should not forget is that in 1214 AD—five years before the start of the first Mongol campaign against the West—Emperor Xuanzong of Jin abandoned the central capital of Beijing out of fear of the Mongols and fled to Kaifeng. Early the following year, the Mongols swiftly captured Beijing, and by 1219, most of Hebei and half of Shanxi were already in their possession.

By the start of the second western campaign in 1235, Western Xia and the Jin Dynasty had successively perished, and half of China was already under Mongol rule. By the start of the third western campaign in 1253–1254, the Mongols had not only subdued the Tibetan Plateau but also completed the strategic encirclement of the Song Dynasty by annihilating Dali and forcing the southwestern barbarian tribes to submit.

These facts fully demonstrate that during the Mongol Empire's conquest of the West, it had obviously become vastly different from a mere nomadic empire. **The Mongols could extract manpower and material resources from the conquered parts of China to serve distant wars. This itself was the consequence of China—especially northern China, where social atomization (社会原子化) was even more severe—being exceedingly easy to conquer.**

The situation faced by the Xiongnu was drastically different from that of the Mongols. The Han Dynasty resisted the Xiongnu's offensive so tenaciously that, although the Xiongnu could wildly expand around the periphery of the Han Dynasty, they were unable to occupy the fully developed territories of the **Zhongyuan** (Central Plains / 中原) to stably extract revenues from them; they could only resort to plundering.

Subsequently, the Xiongnu Empire at its zenith was repelled by the overwhelming offensives of the Han army.

Secondly, the threat from the Xiongnu perceived psychologically by the Han people was further magnified by various factors, primarily reflected in the following five points.

First, as the first nomadic empire in human history (*as for the earlier Scythians, their historical records are pitifully scarce compared to the Xiongnu*), the Xiongnu were an entirely novel adversary for the Han people.

Before the Han Dynasty, the Chinese had never imagined that a **production mode** (生产方式) based on nomadism could generate such a formidable regime. This meant the Han people lacked understanding of the Xiongnu to a considerable degree.

How was this adversary on the Mongolian Plateau politically organized? What were their military combat methods? What was the topography of the Mongolian heartland like? These questions were initially entirely alien to the Han people. It was only through decades of passive counterattacks that they slowly fumbled toward answers to some of these questions.

It was precisely upon the foundation of continuously understanding their arch-enemy that the Han Dynasty acquired the possibility of launching a strategic counter-offensive. Furthermore, it was the

Han military decision-making echelon, headed by Emperor Wu of Han, that gradually groped out how to strategically strike, militarily engage, and diplomatically contain the nomadic regimes on the Mongolian Plateau to achieve the objective of encirclement and strangulation (包围绞杀) during their offensive campaigns against the Xiongnu.

For the Chinese empires subsequent to the Han Dynasty, this dread born of the unknown significantly dissipated. Mongolia was still Mongolia; whether concerning the geopolitical situation of northern China or the characteristics of the nomadic **production mode**, the changes that could occur over a millennium were extremely limited.

This meant that subsequent **Zhongyuan** regimes had a wealth of historical precedent to reference. When facing newly emerging nomadic empires on the Mongolian Plateau, they were no longer completely in the dark (两眼一抹黑); consequently, when confronting such threats, they lacked the acute tension experienced by the Han people.

Second, the expectations regarding the balance of power when confronting northern ethnic minority threats in later generations differed markedly from the early Han Dynasty's perception of the Xiongnu.

When the Han Dynasty was newly established, it was merely a "local regime" (*relative to the entirety of Eurasia*) isolated in eastern Asia, separated from the main parts of the world by continuous plateaus. The Han people possessed an extreme lack of knowledge regarding the world beyond their borders, precisely because these borders had only recently been formed (*as Huaxia expanded to those points*).

Before Emperor Wu of Han, although sporadic, grassroots long-distance trade had long existed, there was genuinely no external corridor capable of facilitating official diplomacy and massive commodity exchange.

Contrasting with this ignorance of the outside world, the Han people could simultaneously and distinctly sense that within the span of two or three generations, the Xiongnu had engaged in massive external expansion, exerting increasingly widespread and formidable military pressure along the entire border of the Han Dynasty.

The very fact that Zhang Qian was dispatched to the Western Regions to contact the Dayuezhi (大月氏)—an ally whose attitude and even location were unclear—demonstrated the Han imperial high command's terror regarding this disadvantageous situation.

The Han Dynasty's economic growth was approaching its limits, yet the Xiongnu's steady expansion over the past decades was still continuing, and the Han people fundamentally could not judge where the limits of Xiongnu expansion lay. This inevitably led contemporaries to realize: **The later the war breaks out, the more disadvantageous the situation will be for us**. Consequently, the tension permeating the entire society intensified.

As China's external communication corridors were completely blasted open by the military during the Han Dynasty, and as the entire Eurasian continent—especially the Eurasian Steppe and the irrigated agricultural zones of Central Asia—was no longer as vast and empty as it was in the 2nd century BC, coupled with the Chinese people's growing familiarity with the characteristics of nomadic ethnic groups, the Chinese empires post-Han found it exceedingly difficult to feel anxious over the potentially boundless growth of nomadic power.

In fact, although Chinese dynasties were subject to the historical **Dynastic cycle** (王朝周期律) due to the existence of the bureaucratic system, the nomadic **production mode** and the climate of the Mongolian Plateau were, in any case, even more unstable.

Thus, from the perspective of the Chinese empires, in most situations, as long as they firmly held their ground for a period of time, once the exceptionally talented Khan of the nomadic empire died, the nomads would often descend into division themselves, either declining to the point of being unable to pose a threat or migrating westward away from China. Judging from the historical facts of the Xianbei (Eastern Han), the Göktürks (突厥), the Uyghurs (回纥), and the Mongols (Ming Dynasty), this viewpoint is undeniably justified.

Third, another psychological consequence caused by the isolation stemming from the lack of external corridors was that, prior to Emperor Wu's counter-offensive, the Han people experienced an intense sense of encirclement and isolation.

The situation facing the Han people was not merely being suppressed by the Xiongnu in the north. The Qiang (羌) in the northwest, the local regimes in the southwest, Nanyue (南越) in the south, Minyue (闽越) in the southeast, and Gojoseon (朝鲜) in the northeast all constituted an encirclement against the Han from their perspective.

A direct consequence of this intense feeling of being absolutely isolated and unaided was the Han Empire's desperate yearning for reliable strategic allies. The fact I have repeatedly mentioned—Zhang Qian's mission to the Western Regions—is the most compelling proof of this.

When people today mention Emperor Wu of Han, they always overemphasize his "martial achievements" (武功). Netizens eagerly relish the various feats of Han envoys "flaunting imperial prestige in alien lands" (扬威异域), yet they frequently overlook Emperor Wu's exceptionally brilliant diplomatic enterprise.

In reality, there were objective, unavoidable reasons why Han envoys appeared exceedingly insolent toward the small city-states in the Tarim Basin (南疆盆地). These city-states, built upon oases, were far too weak compared to massive powers like Han and the Xiongnu. They were already far from the areas under Xiongnu rule, and even further from the Han Dynasty.

Therefore, when facing the sudden appearance and overwhelming superiority of either the Xiongnu or Han armies, these city-states had no choice but to adopt the survival tactic of "submitting to whichever army arrives first."

Thus, when the Han Dynasty's administrative institutions in the Western Regions had not yet been established or were in decline, dispatching a handful of death-defying "**Cossacks bearing imperial tallies**" (持节哥萨克) to threaten these small states with potential military intervention and force them to align with Han was, obviously, the most cost-effective method.

However, toward diplomatic targets that possessed sufficient power to serve as long-term allies, we can clearly see that the empire's genuine foreign policy achieved astounding success.

Besides the alliance between the **Zhongyuan** regimes and the Donghu (Xianbei and Wuhuan) in the northeast mentioned earlier, the Han Dynasty also found a truly enduring ally in the distant northwest: the Kingdom of Wusun (乌孙).

Starting from Emperor Wu of Han, the friendship between the **Zhongyuan** dynasties and Wusun lasted for more than five centuries! Not only did Wusun consistently dispatch troops as an ally of the Han Dynasty in wars against the Xiongnu during the Western and Eastern Han periods, but even after the fall of the Han Dynasty, they continued to pay tribute to Cao Wei as before.

Up until the Northern Wei unified northern China in the 5th century AD, the State of Wusun still presented tribute to the **Zhongyuan** regime. When Northern Wei envoys traveled to the Western Regions and passed through Wusun in 437 AD, they were still received with courtesy by the King of Wusun. Around this time, Wusun gradually lost its independence due to strikes from the Rouran (柔然).

Since Emperor Wu began his foreign ventures among the "barbarians of the four directions" (外事四夷), China's amicable relations with the Donghu and Wusun spanned roughly four to five centuries, and as China's allies, they indeed contributed immensely. In addition, up to the Northern and Southern Dynasties period, no small number of Western Region states still came to offer tribute (*regardless of whether to the Southern or Northern regimes*).

Such prolonged strategic partnerships are not frequently seen even in the entirety of human history, and they are absolutely rare in Chinese history. Aside from the suzerain-vassal relationship (宗藩关系) between China and Joseon (Korea) during the Ming and Qing dynasties, there are no other examples. This alone is sufficient to demonstrate the magnitude of the diplomatic achievements during Emperor Wu's era.

And the very reason the Han Empire so meticulously cultivated diplomatic relations with these newly discovered friends—was it not largely born out of the crisis of previously feeling utterly isolated and unaided?

For the **Zhongyuan** dynasties following the Han, this suffocating threat of encirclement simply did not exist. Up until Tsarist Russia and Western European nations encroached upon China from two directions in the late Qing Dynasty, the enemies, at most, exerted pressure from the north; trade and communication via the southern maritime routes were never entirely severed.

For instance, even when Dali was annihilated by the Mongols and the Southern Song found itself in a posture of being encircled on land, it did not stop the Maritime Trade Supervisorates (市舶司) from continuing to function as usual!

When the Tang Dynasty faced the military threat of the Tibetan Empire (吐蕃), it could easily contact several allies around Tibet to contain it.

Even when the Southern Ming was resisting in its final stages, Koxinga (郑成功) was still attempting to seek reinforcements from Japan, and the Yongli Emperor simply converted to Catholicism, pinning his hopes on the Pope's Crusaders!

Placed in the early Han period, China did not even possess such a hope of relying on an ally for assistance.

An interesting anecdote is that one of the daily tasks of the Daoist alchemists and sorcerers (方士) recruited into the palace by Emperor Wu was to curse the Xiongnu using various magics. The immense pressure borne by the decision-makers of the Han Dynasty is easily imaginable.

Fourth, the lack of "strategic depth" (战略纵深) was another massive difference between the Han Empire facing the Xiongnu prior to Emperor Wu's counter-offensive, and later generations facing northern threats.

Because at that time, the vast regions of the South were either not in Han hands or simply remained undeveloped; they could hardly even be considered part of Huaxia, but were merely the "conquered Baiyue regions" (百越地区).

Therefore, there is a colossal discrepancy between how the Han people perceived the Xiongnu military threat, and how subsequent Chinese regimes viewed northern threats. The latter, having passed through the Eastern Jin, the Sixteen Kingdoms, and the Northern and Southern Dynasties, possessed increasingly rich "experience in fleeing southward" (南渡经验), and the South was indeed becoming increasingly developed, its economy booming and eventually surpassing the North.

In the eyes of the Han people, the middle and lower reaches of the Yellow River Basin constituted, both economically and culturally, virtually the entirety of China. Although the Huai-Si River Basin (淮泗流域) was developing fairly well, it was fundamentally unsuited for large-scale warfare. Thus, in the eyes of the Han people, the strategic depth they possessed against the cavalry-dominated forces of the Xiongnu was pathetically shallow. Once the middle and lower Yellow River fell, it equated to the annihilation of the state.

What forces a person pushed to the brink to suddenly erupt in violent resistance is the severing of all avenues of survival, leaving them with absolutely nowhere to retreat. Is this not exactly the same for a nation?

It was precisely because the various strata of the early Han Empire perceived absolutely no route of retreat when facing the Xiongnu—who were applying pressure across thousands of kilometers of borderlines—that the entire society was far more prone to generating a mindset of staking everything on a single throw to immediately conduct a grand decisive battle (孤注一掷立刻进行大决战).

When we look back at history, it is not difficult to discern that because Emperor Wu of Han himself grew up and matured in this very atmosphere, he possessed an almost superhuman obsession with strategic decisive battles throughout his life.

Even when the Xiongnu had fled far away, and the frontlines were pushed so distant that strangling the Xiongnu via large-scale fortified zones would likely have been more efficient than main-force pitched battles (主力会战), he still repeatedly dispatched massive armies to conduct "trans-Gobi campaigns" (度幕作战 / crossing the Mongolian Gobi to fight). This resulted in the Han army suffering repeated defeats in these pitched battles. It was not until Li Guangli surrendered to the Xiongnu that Emperor Wu finally acknowledged his grave errors in military deployment through the *Edict of Luntai* (《轮台诏》).

For the Chinese regimes of the **restoration-bureaucratic period**, however, "fleeing to the South" (向南逃跑) was an entirely normal option, ready to be placed on the table for discussion. Although a regime content with temporary, ignoble peace in the South (偏安南方) would fearfully still be annihilated eventually, that would at least be several generations later!

Even at the end of the Ming Dynasty, before Emperor Chongzhen hanged himself, he discussed the issue of fleeing South (南迁) with his ministers on several occasions. It was only due to his personal character flaws, and the fact that peasant rebel activities had made the Central Plains unsafe, that ultimately neither the emperor nor the crown prince managed to make the journey.

Chinese history is replete with such examples: psychologically, they always felt there was a route of retreat; if they could not hold the line, they had somewhere else to run, right up until they reached a literal dead end. The mindset of proactive counter-offensive and resolute struggle exhibited by the Han people when facing a formidable threat is simply incomparable to that of subsequent dynasties.

Fifth is the issue of self-confidence.

The Han Empire's successful defeat of the Xiongnu itself provided a powerful psychological suggestion to the nascent Han ethnic identity. Simultaneously, the large-scale conquests conducted during Emperor Wu's era meant that the known world (*more accurately, the geographical regions that possessed significant mutual interaction with China*) no longer harbored any adversary capable of rivaling the Chinese Empire. The tributary system (朝贡体系) was thus fully established.

The consequence of this phenomenon was that the **Zhongyuan** dynasties developed an intense sense of superiority toward the surrounding "barbarian regimes" (蛮夷政权). Subjectively, they constantly disparaged the latter; far from overestimating them, they frequently underestimated their military threats.

If we look at the history of the Southern Ming, we can find that this arrogance frequently reached a level of sheer absurdity. After the Qing army defeated the peasant rebels and entered Beijing, and the Shunzhi Emperor ascended the throne there for the second time, many intellectuals across the vast southern regions—who still formally remained loyal to the Southern Ming (*though not necessarily to the same monarch*)—genuinely believed that as long as they raised local militia forces (团练武装) in their hometowns to launch a Northern Expedition, the Manchus would be effortlessly repelled.

In their eyes, the combat capability of the Eight Banners army (八旗军队) was on the same level as the peasant rebels—which was already utterly ludicrous.

Such a frivolous and arrogant attitude was something the Han Dynasty did not dare to adopt when facing the Xiongnu. True, both sides attempted to gain the upper hand in diplomatic rhetoric, and the Han officialdom naturally denounced the Xiongnu as barbarians. However, the two nations still had to maintain diplomacy based on hard power. Before Emperor Wu decided to counterattack, the Han Dynasty was distinctly the weaker party.

There is a glaring piece of evidence illustrating the Han Empire's regard and respect for an adversary like the Xiongnu: **In the *Records of the Grand Historian* (《史记》) written by Sima Qian, it is explicitly stated that the Xiongnu were the descendants of the royal house of the Xia Dynasty—the very first dynasty in Chinese history.** This account was subsequently inherited by the *Book of Han* (《汉书》).

Comparing this treatment to the incredibly sloppy commentaries in later Chinese historical documents (*excluding, of course, those written by regimes established by ethnic minorities regarding their own origins*)—which casually claimed various ethnic minorities "originated from mixed barbarian stock" (源于杂胡)—the difference is like heaven and earth.

Although we cannot rule out the possibility that Sima Qian wrote this to fulfill the political necessity of "unifying the Three Orthodoxies" (通三统) at the time, directly tracing the origins of the Xiongnu back to the Xia Dynasty and claiming the nation's arch-enemy shared common ancestors with themselves is, in itself, an act of colossal respect toward that arch-enemy. *(Regardless of where the Xia Dynasty specifically was or how long it existed, judging by its vital position in Chinese historical literature, the bloodline of the Xia people had long since melded into the Han ethnicity).*

这一段属于补充性叙述，用来填补原先遗留下的逻辑缺口。在我对已经完成的推导进行梳理的时候发现，我在中国官僚制度形成的部分指出是西汉匈奴对中国形成的巨大压力使得汉帝国做出了激烈的反应，成为致使中国在过早的古典时期出现一个过于完善的官僚制度的主要因素。但是这样就存在一个问题，既然汉代来自北方的重压是官僚体制早熟的原因，而众所周知汉代以后，特别是十六国南北朝时期的少数民族入关结束之后的官僚复辟时期，北方特别是新晋崛起的东北地区对中原王朝的威胁仍然存在，甚至少数民族入关的情况变得更加频繁。那么是否存在这样一种可能，即中国受到的（主要来自北部边境的）军事压力不仅在最初导致了早熟官僚体制的形成，而且在封建化进程中止之后成为复辟官僚体制得以维持的原因呢？事实上，对我来说，就凭我的阅读量和生活经历从直觉上就能够否认这种可能，所以在之前记述的时候我潜意识里就没有打算把这当成一个问题。但是毕竟要想说服他人显然不能通过“我感觉如何”，接下来我将从三个方面进行说明以否定这种可能性。

1，匈奴人的威胁的确在中国历史上与众不同

第一个方面，鼎盛时期的匈奴带给中国的压力，尤其是心理上的压力与其后出现在中国北方的其他强敌相比是极大的。这也就是说，哪怕由于中国离蒙古高原很近，在清朝平定蒙古之前都会一直遭受来自蒙古高原的，其他国家难以想象的游牧民族军事压力，但匈奴在各个蒙古政权中对同时期中国政权造成的压迫和威慑仍然具有显著的特殊性。首先抛开匈奴作为第一个游牧帝国给新生的汉帝国所带来的特定环境下的心理重压，仅仅从史料记载的力量对比来看，能从军事力量上给中国造成与匈奴相媲美的威胁的政权也就只有成吉思汗统一之后的蒙古。事实是即使是成吉思汗刚刚统一蒙古时如朝阳般出生的蒙古政权，其能够动员的兵力也不过十万，作为对比匈奴即使在漠北之战遭到重大战略失败之后 20 年间也能够维持这样的作战兵力。人们很容易通过匈奴帝国和蒙古帝国在征服事业上的优劣来判断其强弱，但是我认为特别应该强调的一点是：蒙古帝国之所以能够强大到征服自从有人类以来政权所能拥有的最大疆域（基本与鼎盛期的大英帝国持平），这本身就是中国因为官僚体制严重衰弱的结果。

人们不应忘记的是，在蒙古第一次西征开始前五年的公元 1214 年，金宣宗就因为恐惧蒙古而放弃了中都北京前往开封，第二年年年初蒙古就迅速夺取了北京，到 1219 年河北大部 and 半个山西已为其所有。到第二次西征开始的 1235 年，西夏和金朝已经相继灭亡，半个中国已经处于蒙古统治下。到第三次西征开始的 1253 至 1254 年，蒙古人不但已经降伏了青藏高原，而且通过消灭大理使西南诸夷臣服完成了对宋朝的战略包围。这些事实充分表明，当蒙古帝国向西方发动征服的过程中，它显然已经与一个单纯的游牧帝国相差很大了，蒙古人可以从被征服的中国部分抽调人力物力去服务于远方的战争，这本身是因为中国特别是社会原子化更严重的北中国极容易被征服所造成的后果。匈奴人面临的情况跟蒙古人差别极大，汉朝如此顽强地抵抗着匈奴的进攻使得匈奴尽管可以在汉朝周边大肆扩张，但是却无法侵占得到充分开发的中原领土进而稳定地从中获得收益，只能采取劫掠的方式。随后，鼎盛的匈奴帝国就被汉军排山倒海的攻势所击退了。其次在心理上汉朝人所感受到的来自匈奴的威胁被各种因素进一步放大，这主要体现在以下五点上。

第一，匈奴作为人类历史上第一个游牧帝国（至于更早期的斯基泰人，其历史记载与匈奴相比实在少到可怜）对于汉人来讲是一个非常新的对手，在汉朝之前中国人从来没想过基于游牧这种生产方式也会产生如此强大的政权，这就意味着汉人对于匈奴相当程度上缺乏认识。这个蒙古高原上的对手在政治上是如何组织的，他们的军事作战方式是什么样的，蒙古腹地的地形地貌如何等等这些问题对汉人来讲一开始都很陌生，在几十年的被动反击中才慢慢摸索出了其中一些问题的答案，也正是在对自己的宿敌不断了解的基础上，汉朝才有了进行战略反击的可能性。而如何在战略上对蒙古高原上的游牧政权进行军事打击，外交遏制以达到包围绞杀目的，则是在以汉武帝为首的汉军决策层在对匈奴的进攻作战中逐

渐摸索出来的。对于汉朝之后的中华帝国而言，这种来自未知的恐惧就大幅消退了，蒙古还是那个蒙古，无论是中国北方的地缘形势也好，还是游牧这种生产方式的特征也罢，千百年来所能发生的变化极为有限。这使得后来的中原政权有大把的历史可以参考，对待蒙古高原上新出现的游牧帝国就不会是两眼一抹黑，在面对其威胁时便缺少了汉人那样的紧张感。

第二，后世面对北方少数民族威胁时对于力量对比的预期显著不同于汉初对匈奴人的看法。当汉朝刚刚建立的时候，它不过是一个孤立在中国东部的，被连绵的高原与世界主要部分相隔开的“地方政权”（相对于整个欧亚大陆而言）汉朝人对自己边境以外的世界极度缺乏认识，这是因为这一边界不过是最近才形成的（华夏扩张到这里）。在汉武帝之前，虽然民间零星的长途贸易早就存在，但是确实不存在任何一条能够进行官方外交和大量商品交换的对外通道。与这种对外部世界的无知相对应的是，与此同时汉朝人能够清清楚楚地感觉到，匈奴人在两三代人的时间里进行了大幅的对外扩张，对于汉朝的整个边境线施加了越来越广泛和强大的军事压力。事实就是，张骞出使西域联络一个态度甚至位置都不明的大月氏作为盟友本身就说明了汉帝国高层对于这种不利局面的恐惧。汉朝的经济增长已经接近极限，而匈奴过去几十年间稳步的扩张还在继续，而且汉朝人根本无法判断匈奴扩张尽头在哪里。这使得当事人的认识必然是：战争越晚一天爆发，形势对我们越不利。因而，全社会的紧张感更加强烈了。随着中国对外联络通道在汉代以军队开路的方式被完全打通，而且整个欧亚大陆特别是欧亚大草原和中亚灌溉农业区也不再像公元前二世纪那样空旷，再加上中国人对于游牧民族本身的特征也逐渐熟悉，汉之后的中华帝国就很难会因为游牧民族力量未知限度的增长而感到担忧。事实上，尽管由于官僚制度的存在中国的王朝存在历史周期律，但无论如何游牧这种生产方式和蒙古高原的气候更加不稳定。于是在中华帝国看来，在大部分情况下只要坚定守住一段时间，等游牧帝国中才能卓越的汗王一死他们往往也就自己陷入分裂，衰退到无法产生威胁或者向西迁移远离中国了。从（东汉）鲜卑、突厥、回纥以及（明代）蒙古的历史事实来看，这种观点无疑是有道理的。

第三，缺少对外通道的封闭性造成的另一个心理上的后果就是汉武帝反击之前的汉朝人存在一种强烈的被包围感和孤立感。汉人所面临的情况不只是在北方被匈奴压制，西北的羌人，西南的地方政权，南部的南越，东南的闽越，东北的朝鲜同样在汉人看来就是构成了对自己的包围。这种强烈的孤立无援的感觉造成的一个直接结果就是汉帝国非常渴望可靠的战略盟友，我反复提到的张骞出使西域就是最有力的证明。人们今天提到汉武帝其人总是过于强调其“武功”的一面，网民们对汉朝使节各种“扬威异域”的壮举津津乐道，往往忽视了汉武帝极其卓越的外交事业。事实上，汉使之所以对南疆盆地的城邦小国显得极为无礼存在无可奈何的客观因素，这些城邦基于绿洲建立，力量相对于汉和匈奴这样的大国太过弱小，距离匈奴的统治区已经很远，距离汉朝就更加遥远了。因此这些城邦国家在面对突然出现的匈奴军队或者汉朝军队压倒性的优势时，为了生存就不得不采取“谁的军队到了投靠”谁这样的办法。因此在汉朝的西域行政机构没有建立或者衰退的时候，派遣少数悍不畏死的“持节哥萨克”以潜在的军事干涉为威胁使得这些小国倒向汉朝显然从成本上是最为划算的。但是对于有充分力量可以作为汉朝的长期盟友的外交对象，我们显然能够看到帝国真正意义的外交政策取得了惊人成功。除了前面已经讲过的中原王朝与东北方鲜卑、乌桓的同盟关系，在遥远的西北方，汉朝还找到了一个真正长久的盟友，乌孙王国。自汉武帝开始中原王朝与乌孙的友谊竟然超过了五个世纪，不但两汉时期乌孙一直作为汉朝的盟友在对匈奴的战争中出兵，汉朝灭亡之后对于曹魏依然朝贡如故。直到公元五世纪北魏统一中国北方之后，乌孙国仍然向中原政权进贡，公元437年北魏使者出使西域经过乌孙时仍然受到乌孙王的礼待。在此前后，乌孙因为柔然的打击而逐渐失去独立。自武帝外事四夷开始，中国与东胡和乌孙的友好关系整体上跨越了四五个世纪之久，并且两者作为中国的盟友的确贡献良多。除此之外，到南北朝时期仍然来贡（无论是向南北哪一方）的西域国家也不在少数。这样长期的战略伙伴关系即使放在人类历史上也不是很多见，而在中国历史上就完全称得上罕见了，除了明清时期中国与朝鲜的宗藩关系以外再无他例，足可见汉武帝时期外交事业的成就。

而之所以汉帝国会对与这些刚刚发现的新朋友的外交关系进行这样细心的经营，很大程度上不正是出于曾经孤立无援的危机感吗？汉朝之后的中原王朝则不存在这样令人窒息的被包围的威胁，直到清朝末年沙皇俄国和西欧国家从两个方向逼近中国之前，敌人充其量也就是在北方施加压力，南方海上的贸易和交流总归不会断。就比如哪怕等到大理被蒙古消灭，南宋已经处于一种在陆地上被包围的态势，这也不影响是市舶司照样发挥作用啊！唐朝面临吐蕃的军事威胁，可以很轻易在吐蕃周围联络几个盟友对吐蕃进行遏制。而南明即使抵抗到最后阶段，郑成功还在试图从日本寻求援军，永历皇帝干脆皈依了天

主教指望教皇的十字军去了。放到汉初，中国就连这样指望一个盟友来帮助自己的希望都不存在。一个有趣的事情是，汉武帝在宫中所招揽的方士其中一个日常工作就是用各种法术诅咒匈奴，汉朝的决策者们承受的压力可想而知。

第四，“战略纵深”的缺乏同样是汉武帝反击之前汉帝国面对匈奴与后世极大不同的一点，因为那个时候南方大片区域要么不在自己手上，要么压根就没怎么开发，甚至很难被视为华夏的一部分而只是“被征服的百越地区”罢了。因此汉朝人看待匈奴军事威胁和经过了东晋十六国南北朝之后拥有了越来越丰富的“南渡经验”，而且南方的开发确实越来越充分，经济越来越发达乃至反超北方的后世中国政权存在非常大的差异。在汉人看来，黄河流域中下游地区无论是经济上还是文化意义上就几乎就是整个中国，淮河流域虽然发展得也不错，但那根本不是用武之地。因此汉朝人眼里自己拥有的战略纵深对于匈奴以骑兵为主的部队而言可谓不多，只要黄河中下游失守，那就等同于亡国。把一个人逼上绝境使之暴起的一定是断掉他的所有活路使之退无可退，其实对一个国家而言何尝不是如此。正是在汉初帝国的各个阶层看来帝国面对在上千公里边境线上全线施压的匈奴本就没有退路，因此整个社会就更容易产生一种孤注一掷立刻进行大决战的思潮。

我们回看历史的时候不难发现汉武帝本人因为就成长并成熟在这样的氛围中，他一生都对战略决战有一种超乎常人的痴迷。哪怕等到匈奴远遁，战线越推越远以至于通过大范围筑垒地域对匈奴进行绞杀在效率上很可能已经优于主力会战的情况下，还是一次又一次派遣大军进行度幕作战（越过蒙古戈壁作战），以至于汉军在会战中屡屡失利。直到李广利投降匈奴汉武帝才终于通过《轮台诏》承认了自己在用兵上存在重大失误。而对于官僚复辟时期的中国政权来说，“向南逃跑”完全是一个非常正常的，可以拿来讨论的选择，虽然偏安南方恐怕还是会被消灭，但是那至少也是好几代人之后。哪怕是在明朝末年，崇祯皇帝在上吊之前也数次与大臣讨论南迁的问题，只不过因其个人性格问题，且农民军活动已经让中原地区不再安全，最终无论是皇帝本人还是太子都没能成行。中国历史上总有这样的例子，心理上总觉得还有退路，守不住了还有地方跑，直到穷途末路。汉代人面对强大威胁时所展现的积极反击，坚决斗争的心态不是后世王朝所能相比的。

第五就是自信心的问题，汉帝国成功击败匈奴本身就给正在形成的汉民族一种有力的心理暗示，同时武帝时期进行的大规模征服使得已知世界（准确来说是与产生显著相互影响的地理区域）不再有了可以与中华帝国抗衡的对手，朝贡体系得以完全确立。这种现象的后果是中原王朝对于周边“蛮夷政权”形成了一种强烈的优越感，总是在主观上对后者进行轻视，非但不会高估反而经常低估其军事威胁。如果我们看南明史就能发现这种自大甚至时常会到一种荒唐的地步，在清军击败农民军进入北京，顺治皇帝又在北京登基一次之后，当时尚在形式上忠于南明（当然未必是同一个君主）的广大南方地区的不少知识分子仍然认为只要在本乡拉起团练武装北伐，满人就会轻而易举地被击退。在他们看来八旗军队的战斗力跟农民军属于一个水平，这就已经十分可笑了。如此轻率傲慢的态度是汉朝面对匈奴时不敢采取的，诚然双方都试图在外交辞令上占对方便宜，汉朝官方当然也会把匈奴斥为蛮夷。然而两国还是不得不维持一种基于实力的外交，在武帝决定反击之前，汉朝还是明显弱势的一方。有一个非常明显的证据说明了汉帝国对于匈奴这样一个对手的重视和尊敬，那就是在司马迁所写的《史记》中明确表示匈奴人是历史上第一个王朝夏朝（王室）的后裔，并且该说法为《汉书》所继承。这种待遇如果与后来中国文献记载（当然不能是少数民族建立的政权记载自己的起源）中各种少数民族“源于杂胡”这样草率的评论可谓是天壤之别。虽然不排除司马迁这样写有当年通三统的政治需求，但是直接将匈奴人的源流追溯到夏代，将本国的宿敌说成与自己拥有共同的祖先（无论夏朝具体在哪，存在了多长时间，从其能够在中国的历史文献中占据如此重要的地位来看，夏人的血脉早就融入汉族中去了）本身就是对宿敌的一种极大尊敬。